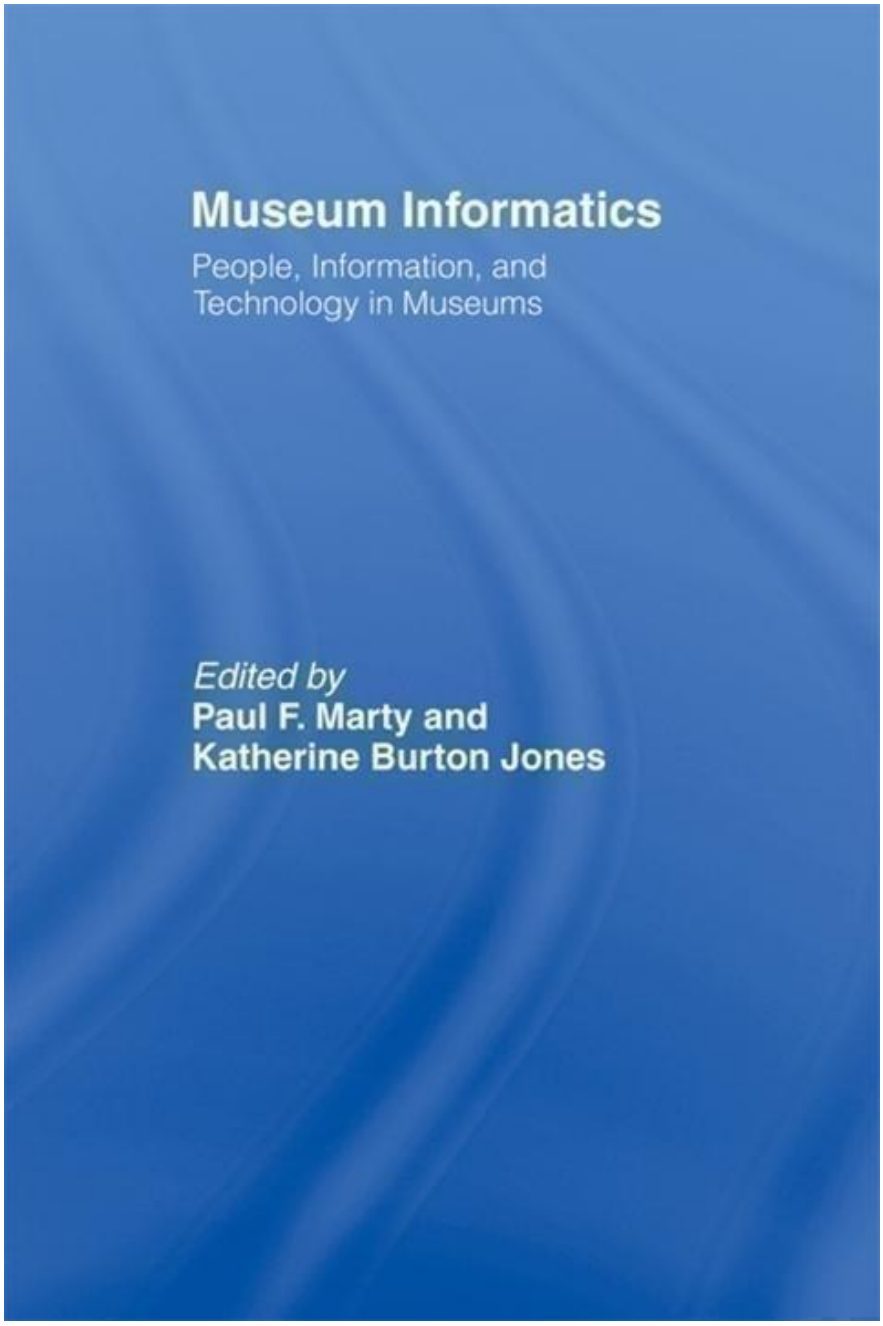
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Transferred to Digital Printing 2009

International Standard Book Number-13: 978-0-8247-2581-5 (0)

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Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Museum informatics : people, information, and technology in museums / edited by Paul F. Marty and Katherine Burton Jones.
p. cm. -- (Routledge studies in library and information science)
Includes bibliographical references and index.
ISBN-13: 978-0-8247-2581-5 (hardback : alk. paper)
1. Museum techniques. 2. Interactive multimedia. 3. Museums--Data processing. I. Marty, Paul F. II. Jones, Katherine Burton.

AM215.M87 2007
069'.1--dc22 2007010937

ISBN-10: 0-8247-2581-6 (hbk)
ISBN-10: 0-415-80218-0 (pbk)

ISBN-13: 978-0-8247-2581-5 (hbk)
ISBN-13: 978-0-415-80218-5 (pbk)

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Preface

Today, in the early 21st century, there is tremendous interest in how people, information, and technology can work together to enhance the museum experience for museum professionals, museum visitors, and all users of museum resources. That so many people are interested in this topic is due in no small part to the contributions of several books covering different aspects of museums and information technology, including:

- *The Wired Museum: Emerging Technology and Changing Paradigms*, edited by Katherine Jones-Garmil (American Association of Museums, 1997);
- *The Virtual and Real: Media in the Museum*, edited by Selma Thomas and Ann Mintz (American Association of Museums, 1998);
- *Digital Collections: Museums in the Information Age*, by Susanne Keene (Butterworth-Heinemann, 1998);
- *Information Management in Museums*, by Elizabeth Orna and Charles Pettitt (Gower, 1998); and
- *Theorizing Digital Cultural Heritage,* edited by Fiona Cameron and Sarah Kenderdine (MIT Press, 2007).

Despite the valuable contributions of these publications, as well as the conference proceedings and academic journals which increasingly help museum researchers and practitioners remain engaged with issues about museums and information technology, few manuscripts have provided a comprehensive look at the role of museums in the information society. In particular, there is a need for an approach that merges current theoretical and practical perspectives about people, information, and technology in museums, and does so in a way that is accessible to museum researchers and professionals worldwide. The goal of this book, therefore, is to offer a unique perspective on these topics that when combined with the works listed above will provide fresh, complementary insights for the museum community.

Museum Informatics explores the sociotechnical issues that arise when people, information, and technology interact in museums. It is designed specifically to address the many challenges faced by museums, museum

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professionals, and museum visitors in the information society. It examines not only applications of new technologies in museums, but how advances in information science and technology have changed the very nature of museums, both what it is to work in one, and what it is to visit one. Museum professionals face new information management challenges, from making decisions about content management software to selecting metadata standards for sharing information with other institutions. Museum visitors come with new expectations about the resources museums should provide, asking questions that rely on an unprecedented level of information access and expecting most of the answers to be available online. These issues reflect just some of the new needs, challenges, and expectations that have arisen as museums adapt to their new role in the information society.

To explore these issues, this book offers a selection of contributed chapters, written by leading museum researchers and practitioners, that cover the latest scientific and technological advances relevant to museums and information resources. The chapters are arranged into seven sections, each covering a different theme or concept fundamental to museum informatics. Each section opens with an introductory chapter that sets the stage for the contributed chapters and provides a continuous narrative about museum informatics that connects the book's chapters into one integrated whole. The contributed chapters alternate between theoretical chapters discussing the latest research on a variety of museum informatics topics, and practical chapters providing significant examples and detailed case studies useful for museum researchers and professionals. The seven sections of the book are arranged as follows:

The book opens with an introduction to museum informatics, discussing the emergence of museum informatics as an interdisciplinary field of study and examining the origin, nature, and transformation of the digital museum.

The second section explores the role of information representation in museums, analyzing the methods by which museums represent the knowledge inherent to their collections, and examining how museums have managed the information revolution in their own environments.

The third section covers information organization and management in museums, exploring how museums establish and promote information policies that connect museum resources and their users, and discussing the metadata structures that govern access to museum information.

The fourth section analyzes the growing importance and integration of interactive technologies into museum exhibits, exploring the ways in which new technologies have revolutionized the museum visitor experience, and examining the potentials for new technologies to blur the boundaries between in-house and online museum experiences.

The fifth section explores the changing needs and expectations of museum audiences, discussing the importance of understanding and evaluating the needs of museum visitors, in-house and online, and examining the potential

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of meeting new needs in museum education by connecting online resources to classroom environments.

The sixth section discusses the role of collaborations and consortia for meeting shared museum goals, providing examples that illustrate the challenges faced by museums when creating and sustaining museum collaborations, as well as the benefits that cooperative activities offer to participating museums.

The final section examines the future of museums and museum professionals, exploring the meaning of museum information professionals curating information resources on the cyberinfrastructure and exploring the future of museums in the information society.

In this way, *Museum Informatics* takes a fresh look at the sociotechnical interactions that occur between people, information, and technology in museums. It is our sincere hope that this book presents its information in a format accessible to multiple audiences, including academic researchers, students interested in museum careers, museum professionals, and museum visitors.

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Acknowledgments

We would like to acknowledge the assistance of the students enrolled in the Museum Informatics (LIS 5590) course in the College of Information at Florida State University, and the Museums and the Web (MUSE E130) course offered through the Museum Studies program at the Harvard Extension School. The students in these courses were instrumental in testing the suitability of drafts of this manuscript for instruction in both Museum Studies and Library and Information Science programs. Thanks are also due to the teaching assistants for these two courses, Jason Springer and Adam Rozan at Harvard, and Kim Thompson at FSU. Finally, we would like to acknowledge the special assistance provided by Nancy Enterline, a recent graduate of the Florida State University College of Information, who served as the research assistant for this project.

Paul F. Marty
Katherine Burton Jones

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Section 1

Introductions

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